

Is Cyberbullying the biggest problem facing today's youth?

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Imagine a life where you cannot escape a bully, one who is with you everywhere—even at home, even when you are with your family. The insults follow you whenever you close the door, and the harassment continues when you turn off the lights. Each time your phone vibrates, or you hear a notification sound, your mind is jolted back to the knowledge that you are being surveilled, ridiculed, or shamed by people who may never use their real names. Unlike typical bullying, which stops when the bully is not physically present, cyberbullying can extend into a victim's home and even infiltrate their bedroom. Young people who are targeted by online bullying are statistically more likely to experience depression, higher levels of anxiety, increased anger, and even suicidal thoughts compared to non-bullied youth. The ramifications of cyberbullying extend beyond mental health and can affect a victim's academic performance, relationships with parents and peers, and ability to participate in social life. Cyberbullying is not simply a personal challenge but the most significant issue for today's adolescents because its harm to mental health, academic success, and social well-being represents a public health challenge and a social crisis requiring urgent attention from schools, families, and policymakers.

The psychological toll of cyberbullying is among its most damaging effects, often leaving adolescents with lasting emotional scars. For many youths, the stress is not limited to occasional teasing; it can become a daily experience that affects every interaction and decision. Research indicates that youth who were targets and perpetrators of bullying reported feeling sadder, worried, and angrier than those youths who were not involved. Victims often describe feeling isolated and trapped, as if there is no safe place online or offline where they can escape the harassment. Adolescents who were bullied online (targets) and bullies themselves (perpetrators)—now often referred to as "cyberbully-victims"—were found to have the most

severe outcomes, including suicidal ideation and other risky behaviors (Skilbred-Fjeld et al., 2020). These individuals frequently experience confusion, guilt, and shame, struggling to reconcile their own actions with the harm they receive or cause. Similarly, a review of studies found that adolescents repeatedly bullied online were more likely to suffer from depression and stress. They also tended to use substances like drugs or alcohol and engage in risky behavior compared to those who were not bullied (Bottino et al., 2015). These findings indicate that cyberbullying burdens both victims and perpetrators. It can also worsen pre-existing issues such as family instability, unsafe schools, and strained peer relationships. Because trolling can reach victims anytime through digital devices, the harassment feels constant and overwhelming. These psychological consequences show that cyberbullying is a private struggle and a threat to community well-being. Although the mental health impacts of digital cruelty are severe, it also has harmful effects on students' daily lives.

Cyberbullying has serious consequences for youth's school performance and social development—it is more than simply a personal mental health issue. Victims of online abuse may continue to get lower marks, miss more school, and even drop out due to the stress and shame of being bullied online (Peled, 2019). For many students, the anxiety begins the moment they wake up, as they anticipate new messages, posts, or comments that could escalate the harassment. Because online bullying can occur anytime, many adolescents experience that anxiety even at school, which can affect their studying and socializing with their peers. An example from Germany shows that after students were exposed to cyberbullying, both regular and special needs students became more socially withdrawn and participated less in class (Schütz et al., 2022). This demonstrates further damaging consequences for inclusion in school. Not only do these issues affect schools, teachers, and families, but they also create a ripple effect on

students' and families' social lives. In some ways, it creates even more anxiety than traditional bullying because traditional bullying stops when they leave school and perhaps becomes less frequent when they leave a given location (e.g., a park). The constant fear of humiliation online makes it difficult for students to focus on class or participate in group activities, gradually lowering their academic confidence and motivation. It has a more detrimental effect on students' academic engagement and social participation than many other problems facing youth today. The disruption to learning and relationships shows that it is an educational issue, and it is also a hindrance to adolescent social development in a larger sense.

Cyberbullying has surfaced as an urgent community health and public policy issue, with schools, families, and the community at large still looking for effective ways to address it. While most educators understand that digital harassment can be very damaging, many school-based prevention programs fail due to badly designed lesson plans or uninspired content. Research has indicated that students disengage out during “normal” classroom discussions on the topic yet seem to engage more when an outside professional—police officer, mental health specialist, etc—makes 'real-life' presentations about cyberbullying. For example, Police officers have presented mock case reports illustrating the legal, social, and psychological consequences of online harassment (Tomczyk & Włoch, 2019). This example shows the greater complexity about cyberbullying: that simply providing information is not enough—students need relatable, tangible examples of the seriousness of the topic. It should also be remembered that adults aren't immune; teachers and school personnel are similarly victimized. One study from Europe indicated that in 11% of schools, personnel themselves had been subjected to digital mistreatment (Vandebosch et al., 2014). The reality is that this issue affects not just students and schools but the school community. When harms extend beyond the student, trust breaks down,

and the decrease in trust renders the student and the adult school community less safe. The vulnerability of both students and staff to online cruelty highlights that the harm extends beyond personal conflict; it is a societal problem, and, importantly, it is a problem that we must all pay attention to. Schools, parents, and policymakers must collaborate to reduce aggression and address its root causes. Together, we should strive to create safer online environments. Though there is a lot of thinking and discussion surrounding the construct of cyberbullying, it is also noted by some researchers that it is not the only problem that adolescents face today.

Others may argue that even larger threats than cyberbullying confront Gen Z in modern society these days, including technology addiction and substance use. Technology addiction is a widespread phenomenon, with many adolescents spending countless hours scrolling through social media and gaming platforms every week, leading to declines in school performance, sleep, and friendships in the real world (Griffiths, 2015). Substance use is a similarly troubling issue: approximately one in six teens struggle with significant drug or substance use disorder, a situation that can harm their health and lead to lifelong addictive behavior (Thorne & DeBlassie, 1985). These problems are undeniably very serious, and many adolescents have them. However, the effects of cyberbullying can go deeper because it is constant, intrusive, and often invisible to adults as it happens. Moreover, it is difficult for the victim or bystander to stop this form of abuse. Moreover, cyberbullying can contribute to or worsen other issues identified by researchers, such as technology addiction, risky behaviors, and substance use. Adolescents may engage in excessive screen time, rage, or risky behaviours to relieve stress and humiliation. Some may even turn to substance use. These students are often considered resistant to disciplinary action, which makes intervention even harder.

In conclusion, online harassment represents the largest risk for young people today, even more so than addiction to technology or unsafe use of alcohol or drugs. The implications of cyberbullying can almost certainly be exacerbated by the fact that it is constant, pervasive, and in most cases invisible to adults. Young people, therefore, cannot escape it. This issue is not only about the mental health and well-being of youth. Victims experience depression, anxiety, anger, suicidal thoughts, poor academic performance, erosion of friendships, and physical fights when they experience repeated online attacks because of cyberbullying. The impact of digital cruelty extends to families and the school community as well. Trust erodes, unsafe learning environments are created, and social dynamics are shifted between students and staff. As harmful as other issues may be to our youth, online aggression uniquely worsens them—especially excess screen time, substance use, and other maladaptive behaviours. We must take the implications of cyberbullying seriously because of its severity, lasting effects, and unpredictable nature. It is not only a public health concern but also a deep social crisis. There needs to be a unified response by schools, families, policymakers, and the community to create safe online spaces, model appropriate behavior, and intervene and support those who may be victimized. If we do not intervene, we will be costing an entire generation of children their adult futures as we watch cruel behaviour continue.

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